

Resource: Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Oppression of God's People, Our Advocate, Overcoming the Devil

Oppression of God's People

God does not want his people to suffer under oppression. From the time when God freed the Israelites from slavery in Egypt under Moses (the exodus), to when Joshua led them to conquer the promised land, and through David's battles, God's goal for Israel was complete victory over their enemies (see [Joshua 1:1-9](#)). In a similar way, the New Testament often speaks of freedom from the oppression or control of sin as an essential blessing of a relationship with Jesus ([Romans 6:1-14](#); [Galatians 5:1-15](#)).

Why does oppression exist? The book of Judges suggests it is because of human disobedience. If Israel obeyed God he promised victory in the conquest. Yet, at best they only partially obeyed him ([Judges 1:19-36](#)). With the rewards of victory available, why did God's past people fail as well as the church today?

In Judges, a new generation grew up that did not participate in the exodus from Egypt or Joshua's conquest of Canaan. Their faith relied on stories of divine acts from the past. They had not personally witnessed "all the great works that the LORD had done for Israel" ([Judges 2:7](#)). This generation "did not know the LORD or the works that He had done for Israel" ([2:10](#)).

God allowed enemies to remain in the land "to test all the Israelites" ([3:1-4](#)). But Israel did not expel these enemies as God commanded. The rest of the book of Judges shows the tragic results of that failure.

God allows his people to experience the consequences of turning away from him ([Judges 2:12-14](#)). But God remains faithful and does not ultimately abandon those who truly worship him. Even in judgment, God punishes for good. He teaches his people obedience.

The enemies who took Israel's blessings became part of God's test of Israel's faithfulness. We can learn from oppression, as both physical and spiritual battles need discipline. This experience can lead to a "a harvest of righteousness and peace" (see [Hebrews 12:5-11](#)).

Through Jesus Christ, God provided undeserved salvation from the worldwide oppression of sin, "while we were still sinners" ([Romans 5:8](#)). The Israelites experienced salvation from their enemies when they turned in repentance to the Lord. So, we can experience salvation from the greatest oppressive force when we turn to God in repentance.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 26:14-39](#); [Deuteronomy 8:19-20](#); [28:15-68](#); [Judges 2:2-3](#), [10-15,18](#); [3:1-8](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [Ezekiel 22:27-29](#); [Amos 4:1](#); [James 2:1-7](#)

Our Advocate

In the Gospel of John, the Greek word *paraklētos* refers to the Holy Spirit. This word literally means "called alongside" and describes him as "Advocate" ([John 14:16, 26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7](#)). This term appears in other Greek texts, where it refers to a legal advocate. This is someone who speaks in a person's defense in court and gives legal advice.

"Counselor" is a common translation, but its modern meaning related to psychology can be misleading. The older legal sense of a lawyer giving advice is more accurate.

"Comforter" is another common translation, but it can also be misleading. The older English meaning of someone who strengthens, or an "encourager," aligns better with the New Testament idea of *paraklētos*.

Jesus described the Spirit as *another* "Advocate" ([John 14:16](#)). Jesus, the first advocate, sent the Holy Spirit as the second Advocate (see [1 John 2:1](#)).

Every task of the Spirit described in [John 14–16](#) is a task Jesus performed elsewhere in the gospel stories. Jesus promised that the Holy Spirit would come to encourage, instruct, and strengthen his followers. The Spirit would maintain Jesus' presence among his disciples. Five promises about the Spirit show different works the Spirit does ([John 14:16–17, 26; 15:26; 16:7–8, 13–14](#)).

The Spirit became available to Jesus' disciples after his death (see [John 7:39; 20:22](#)). The Spirit now continues Jesus' work and presence in the lives of Christians ([14:16–26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:25; 24:15; 2 Samuel 15:12; 1 Kings 12:6–14; 1 Chronicles 27:32; Job 16:18–22; Isaiah 1:26; 9:6; John 14:1–16:15; Galatians 3:19–20; 6:13; 1 Timothy 2:5; Hebrews 8:6; 9:15; 12:24; 1 John 2:1](#)

Overcoming the Devil

The New Testament writers believed in the reality of evil and the dangers of the spiritual world. They saw Satan, also known as "the evil one" or "the devil," as a serious threat. The devil blocks the work of God's people (see [1 Thessalonians 2:18; Revelation 2:10](#)). He "prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour" ([1 Peter 5:8](#)).

The entire world that does not trust in Christ is under the power of sin and the devil (see [Ephesians 2:2; 1 John 5:19](#)). Paul calls the devil "the god of this age has blinded the minds of unbelievers" (see [2 Corinthians 4:4](#); compare [Matthew 13:19](#)). Satan opposes God and tries to destroy his people ([Revelation 12:12, 17](#)). But Jesus came to destroy "the works of the devil" ([1 John 3:8](#)).

God changes into good what the devil intends for evil. Following this idea, the apostle Paul tells the church at Corinth to remove someone from the Christian community. This way, by encountering the devil's destructive power, that person would repent and find salvation (see [1 Corinthians 5:5](#)).

Christians should submit to God and resist the devil ([James 4:7](#)). They should pray for God's help ([Matthew 6:13](#)). They should use the spiritual armor God provides for protection ([Ephesians 6:10–20](#)). Those who obey Satan experience consequences (see [Acts 5:1–5](#)). Obedient Christians are safe because they know Christ's death on the cross has stopped the devil's power

(see [Romans 8:38–39; 1 Corinthians 15:24; Colossians 1:13; 2:10, 15; 1 Peter 3:22](#)).

The Lord protects them (see [1 John 5:18](#)). They also know the Holy Spirit within them is stronger than the devil (see [1 John 4:4](#)). Through God's word, they can defeat the evil one (see [1 John 2:14](#); compare [Revelation 12:11](#)).

Christians should be cautious of the devil and guard against his influence. But they should not live in fear. God's power is much greater than the devil's. In the end, God will completely defeat the devil (see [Revelation 20:7–10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 6:13; 13:19; Acts 5:3–5; Romans 8:38–39; 1 Corinthians 5:5; 15:24; 2 Corinthians 4:4; Ephesians 2:2; 4:27; 6:10–20; Colossians 1:13; 2:10, 15; 1 Thessalonians 2:18; James 4:7; 1 Peter 3:22; 5:8; 1 John 2:14; 3:8; 4:4; 5:18–19; Revelation 2:10; 12:7–9, 11–12, 17](#)